

A PRABHAKAR RAO



CHAMUNDI DENIES CHARGES OF LAVISH LIFESTYLE BUT DRIVES A MERCEDES

be proved only if cyber forensic experts examined his mobile phones.

Chamundi puts on a brave face, not merely denying the charges but calling them a ploy to oust him from his authority. "The decision of suspension came in my absence and reveals a sinister motive of some members of the ACA," he says. The flamboyant official, last seen in public at Captain M.S. Dhoni's side during the World T20 event during press conferences, has also sought security cover, claiming that there is threat to his life from some officials of the association.

In fact, it was Chamundi who got the earlier ACA president Venkata Rao dislodged and brought in his associate Gokaraju Gangaraju in order to exercise greater control of the association. Unfortunately for him, the move backfired. "This is a power game as Gangaraju, who owns sugar factories, wants to edge me out and get closer to BCCI President Sharad Pawar," says Chamundi.

J. Durga Bhavani, another member of the Andhra women cricket team, says, "He is always ready to grant special favours to those who are attractive and obey his dictates. The inducements ranged from offering trips abroad, selection to the under-19 national or the state teams. Those of us who resisted were harassed."

Chamundi denies the charges strenuously saying he has always had

Tale of WOES

J. Durga Bhavani, a member of the Andhra women cricket team, recounts her experience

I used to get calls from Chamundi asking me to come over. There have been many instances when he has asked me to collect my dues from his residence. When I underwent a surgery, I had to join a gym in a Vijayawada hotel to strengthen my leg and he insisted on giving me personal attention. All this made me uncomfortable. One day when I could not go for practice, he asked me the reason and when I told him I had a personal problem he started abusing me. He once invited me to Bangalore, promising to buy me an expensive kit and even went to the extent of saying that "I could never afford it". When the T20 team was announced, he called to say I was selected and when I thanked him he said, "You should say it with a hug". This happened many times and continued for another eight months. It was only when Savita Kumari, our captain, came out in the open that I mustered courage to complain.

the welfare of the state's athletes at heart. "When I can help Saina Nehwal and Sania Mirza who are not cricketers, how can I have such an attitude towards cricket players?"

Allegations of financial irregularities include Chamundi's deal with the Delhi-based Superior Furniture to buy 24,000 chairs for Rs 1,350 each for the ACA stadium in Visakhapatnam. His defence is that he spent Rs 150 less of what the Jharkhand Government did for the same chairs. "The real truth will be out soon," he says. There is another story of how he was negotiating a similar over-priced deal for lighting equipment and floodlights which did not materialise.

Controversy and Chamundi though have gone hand in hand. One of Andhra cricket's most famous networkers, he was close to former India captain Mohammed Azharuddin. He was also questioned by the CBI in the aftermath of the ignominious match-fixing scandal in 2000. Unfazed, Chamundi befriended and remained besotted with other popular cricketers, like Sachin Tendulkar. There are allegations that he advised Tendulkar in making real estate investments in and around Hyderabad.

He has also acquired a reputation of gifting cars to Hyderabad's sports stars on their moments of glory. So badminton ace P. Gopichand received a Hyundai Accent, tennis star Mirza a Palio, women's cricket captain Mitali Raj a Chevrolet and badminton champion Nehwal a Honda City. The money was raised not from Chamundi's own coffers but from his rich friends and well-wishers.

"There is a joy in recognising talent and celebrating it," says Chamundi, who claims to be a zamindar, but is reported to have made his money both from stocks and real estate. The clerk from Syndicate Bank who played 44 first-class matches has come a long way becoming an influential mandarin of Andhra Pradesh cricket, but for the moment, Mr Quick Fix is trapped on a sticky wicket. ■